The absence of major trading centers within Ghur meant little to report for the early Arabic-language geographers,[4] or other authors such as the anonymous writer of the tenth-century *Hudud al-'Alam* (*c.* 982 CE) – which betrays the proclivities and aims of these authors (and their modern heirs) rather than the historical importance of the region. In a similar vein during the eleventh century, the Ghuris rarely arrested the attention of Ghaznavid-period chroniclers such as al-'Utbi (*c.* 961–1036/1040 CE) and Baihaqi (AH 385–469/995–1077 CE), and when they did, it was not in flattering terms: they were recipients of punitive action for their banditry along caravan routes. The three well-known Ghaznavid expeditions into Ghur – two by Sultan Mahmud (r. AH 389–421/999–1030) to the fortified settlement of Ahangaran on the Hari Rud (cf. Chapter 2) and Khwabin in southern Ghur, and a third by his son Mas'ud (eventually Sultan Mas'ud I, r. AH 421–432/1030–1041) to the fortress at Jurwas (map, p. xvi) – were motivated both by the cessation of previously stipulated tribute to the Ghaznavid treasury, and by the Ghuris' disruption of caravan traffic.[5]

Considering the practical impossibility of entire caravans traversing the difficult terrain of the region, the Ghuris' brigandage likely took place on the major routes radiating from Herat and essentially skirting Ghur itself, either proceeding northeast toward Balkh and eventually India through the Khyber and other Gandharan passes; or headed southeastward toward Tiginabad/Old Qandahar, Baluchistan, Sindh, and ultimately the Indo-Gangetic plains.[6] Although these reports provided few specific facts, such as exactly where the bandit raids took place or indeed the commodities the raiders sought in waylaying the caravans,[7] they did indicate in broad terms that at least segments of Ghur's inhabitants practiced some form of banditry, likely as a supplement to other modes of production.[8] Furthermore, the lack of sustained passage of outside populations through Ghur surely also impacted its linguistic culture, as the dialect of Persian spoken here – or perhaps another language altogether – required Prince Mas'ud to rely on translators during his campaign.[9] The prevailing understanding of the region up to the twelfth century has largely followed the eminent C. E. Bosworth's (1928–2015) characterization: it had "no towns of note, but only agricultural settlements and – [the] most typical feature of the landscape – fortified places and towers (*qasr*, *qala*, *hisar*, *kushk*)"[10] marked a politically fragmented region, whose largely pastoral and bellicose inhabitants "practis[ed] agriculture and banditry [and] specialized in the production of weapons and war equipment."[11]

While the overall picture of historical Ghur and Ghuris is further enriched throughout this volume (see esp. Chapter 2), the ongoing scholarly efforts to re-integrate nomadic and transhumant populations into fuller apprehensions of regional histories and economies should be noted here. For example, M. S. Mahmud's Persian-language monograph on the Shansabanis[12] has initiated a much-needed re-examination of the evidence